

*You know now.*

*The cook with the ladle — the man who tested you, who trusted you, who sent you into the castle. Jordan is Hans von Baysen: the chairman of the Council, the man this letter was meant for from the very first hour.*

*Outside, the carnival is burning itself out. The pipes have gone quiet, the masks coming off all over Thorn — and yours with them. No more faces to wear.*

*The letter has ridden in your bag since morning. Sealed, unread, unbroken — and so it stays. Whatever words are folded inside, they were never yours to know. You were only ever the hands that carried it.*

*It ends at the castle. At Przedzamcze, where the Order's fortress stands in ruin, the eighth bell will bring two men into the dark.*

*One is the chairman — the man who was Jordan all along. The other is Albrecht, the Komtur, the Order's hand in Thorn. Between them, a single choice: into whose hands the letter goes.*

*The eighth bell. The ruins. You walk.*